

Write Choices

Also Remember...

- Types of media that can be used are CD-R and CD-RW. The advantage of the more expensive CD-RW media is that it is reusable.
- If you are planning to buy a writer that is faster than 8x then you might find that your system is incapable of feeding the writer with data at the required rate. This is usually due to slower hard drives, low processing power and limited RAM.
- Most manufacturers provide regular firmware upgrades on their Web sites for their drives ensuring that they are capable of using the latest types of media and formats.
- 700 MB CD-Rs are now available at the same cost as the regular 650 MB media.

The reduction in cost of blank media has made CD-R and CD-RW writers an inexpensive storage option for PC enthusiasts. The 4x devices which would take around 20 minutes to burn a CD just a year ago have graduated to burning CDs in less than 5 minutes with the newer 24x units. Issues such as the buffer underrun problems associated with older drives have been solved in new writers. These drives are available in a number of different interfaces, of which IDE is the most popular due to lower overhead costs and easier installation. Other alternatives include SCSI, USB and Firewire.

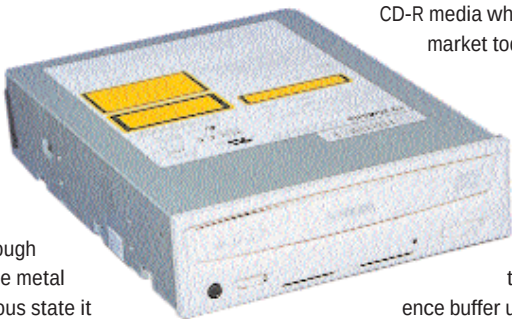
The actual cost of the CD writers has come down due to increased competition between vendors and they range between Rs 6,000 for basic 8x units to Rs 20,000 for the blazingly fast 24x models.

TECHNOLOGY INSIGHT

CD-Writers are similar to regular CD-ROM drives except that they let you burn the data on blank media. The media has a compound layer which in the crystalline state allows the laser beam to pass through and reflects it back from the metal layer. When in the amorphous state it doesn't allow reflection of light. This describes the 1 and 0 states of information storage. The laser beam is powerful enough to melt the dye of the media for writing but the intensity of beam needed for erasing information is somewhat lower.

SMART TIPS

Speed: The fastest recording speed currently available in the market is 24x whereas 10x is the fastest rewrite speed available. The media that supports these speeds, however, is not widely available. The fastest



CD-R media which is freely available in the market today is 16x.

Interface: IDE is the least expensive and most popular option. SCSI models require an additional SCSI card to be installed but result in lower CPU utilisation and do not usually experience buffer underrun problems. External models tend to use the USB interface.

BURN proof technology: Most new CD-Writers incorporate some form of BURN proof technology but the effectiveness tends to vary. From our experience, the Plextor drives are particularly good in this respect.

Bundled software: Some CD authoring software is bundled with every drive. These could either be proprietary or a third-party product. Adaptec's EasyCD Creator and Ahead Software's Nero Burning ROM are the most popular of these.

	Inexpensive data backup	Speed demon	Portability
You need	Speed is not an issue; you are just looking for a cheap, reliable backup solution	Speed is everything, and you have no intention of spending more than 5-6 minutes to burn a CD.	To regularly back up data from different PCs.
Look for	An 8x drive	Preferably 16x or higher write speeds, and a SCSI interface.	A compact, external drive with a USB interface.
Our pick	Samsung SW-208	HP 9700i (16/10/40x), ACeR CRW 1610A (16/10/40x)	Acer 6424
Price range	Less than Rs 8,000	Rs 8,000 to Rs 20,000	Rs 12,000 and above

The Final Verdict on
Hardware & Software

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